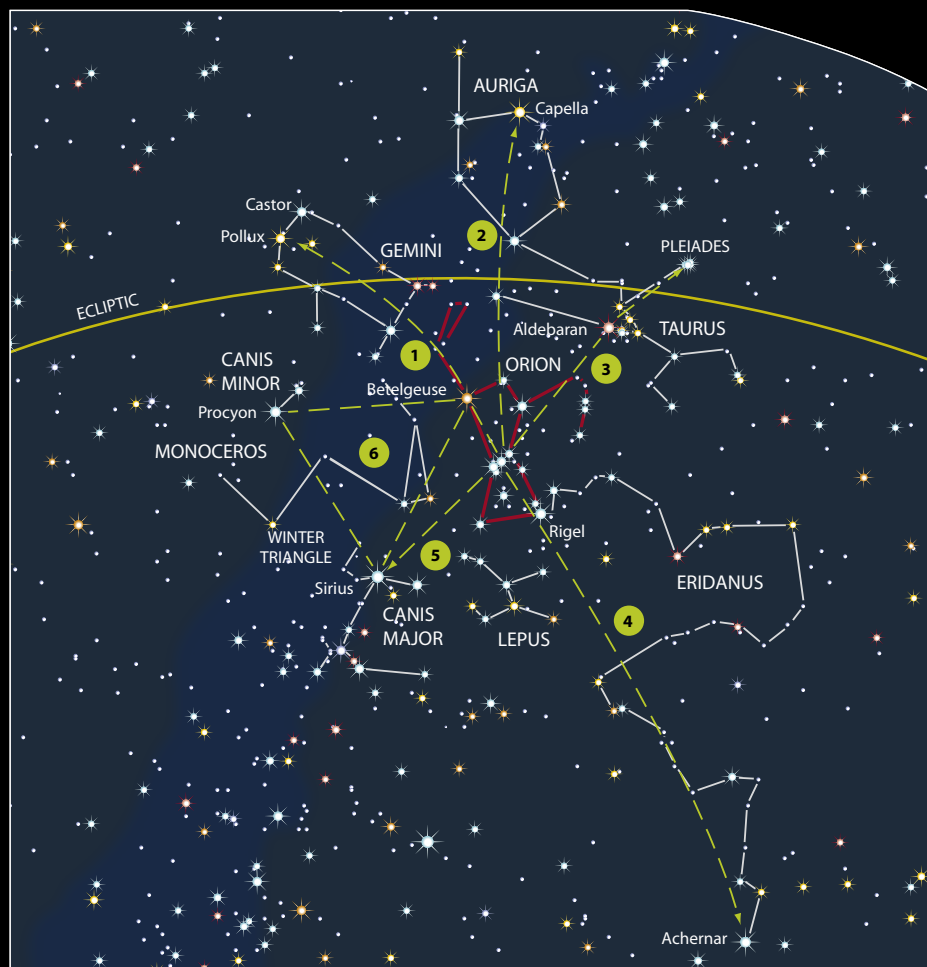


MIDLATITUDES

The figure of Orion is a prominent presence. Three stars in the hunter's belt are the starting point for exploring a rewarding area of sky.

- 1 Extend a line from the belt, through Betelgeuse and beyond Orion's raised arm, to reach Gemini, the twins.
- 2 Hop from the belt of Orion to his head, go the same distance again to the star at the end of Taurus the bull's horn, and continue to Capella.
- 3 Hop from the belt to Orion's left hand; hop the same distance again to reach the Pleiades star cluster, passing through Taurus's face on the way.
- 4 A line from Betelgeuse to Rigel and extended on through a relatively barren area of sky reaches the bright star Achernar.
- 5 Follow the line of Orion's belt past his lower body and on to the unmistakably brilliant Sirius.
- 6 Hop from Betelgeuse to Sirius and the same distance again to Procyon to make an equilateral triangle of stars called the Winter Triangle.



Orion, the hunter

Orion is a well-defined constellation, and its pattern is easily found. Most observers can see Orion at some time in the year; only those north of latitude 79°N and south of 67°S never see it.

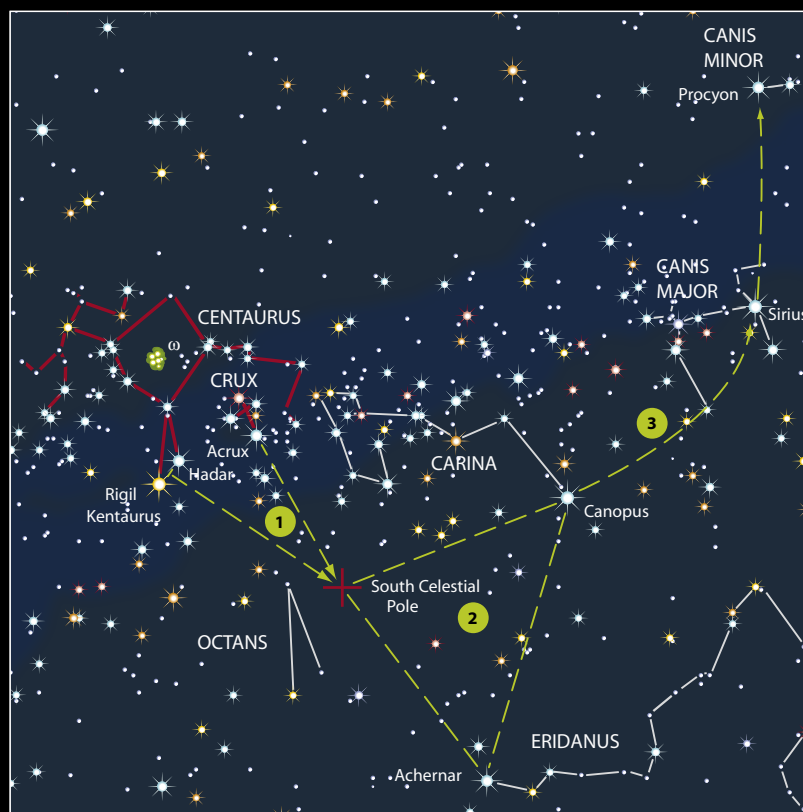


STAR HOPPING

SOUTHERN LATITUDES

The four bright stars in Crux and the two brightest in Centaurus are embedded in the Milky Way's path. Just a hop away are other brilliant stars.

- 1 Extend the long axis of Crux, the cross, and another line from between the stars Hadar and Rigil Kentaurus, the third-brightest star of all. The two lines meet at the unmarked position of the south celestial pole, which is about halfway to the bright star Achernar.
- 2 A triangle of lines links the south celestial pole, around which the circumpolar stars revolve, to Achernar, the ninth-brightest star of all, and to Canopus, the second-brightest.
- 3 Find brilliant Sirius, the brightest star in all of the sky, by lengthening and curving the line from Canopus. Hop about the same distance again to Procyon, the eighth-brightest star. Sirius and Procyon are two of the three stars that form the Winter Triangle, shown in the midlatitude sky map above.



Crux, the southern cross

Crux is the smallest constellation of all, but its four prominent stars and location in the Milky Way make it a favorite of southern observers. It can be seen from anywhere in Earth's southern hemisphere.